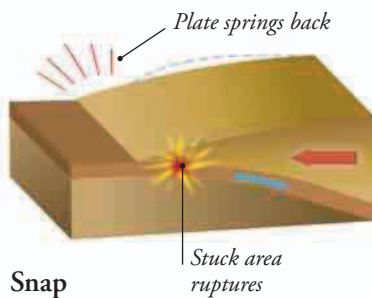
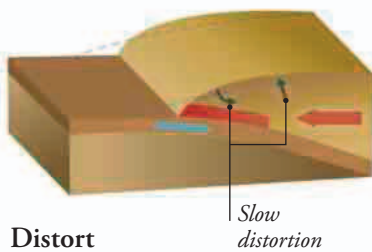
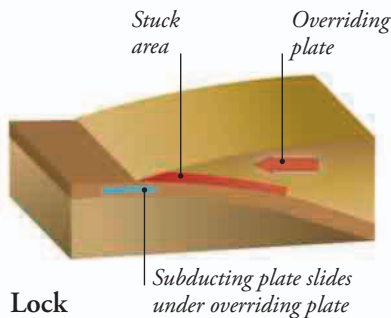


LOCK AND SNAP

If two plates of Earth's crust lock together at a plate boundary, this doesn't stop them from moving. The edges of the plates just get distorted like giant springs, building up tension. When the boundary finally gives way, the plates spring back and all the movement that might have taken place over many years happens within minutes. The sudden shock is what generates an earthquake.

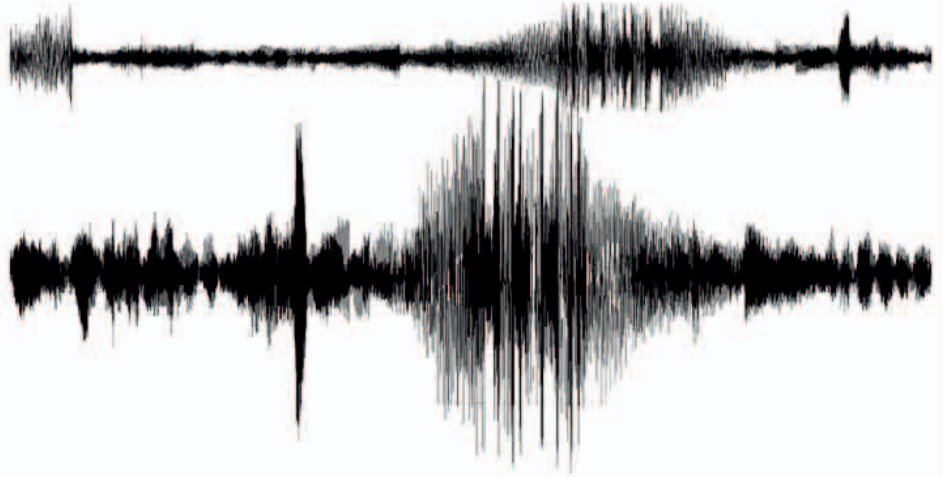


FAST FACTS

- There are roughly half a million earthquakes every year.
- The biggest earthquake recorded so far hit 9.5 on the Richter scale.
- A deadly quake killed around 316,000 people in Haiti in 2010. The widespread damage badly hampered rescue efforts.

THE RICHTER SCALE

Earthquake waves are picked up and recorded using seismometers or seismographs. They are often measured on the Richter scale of magnitude. Each increase in number represents ten times the shaking force, so a category 7 earthquake is ten times as powerful as a category 6. The earthquake that caused the 2011 tsunami in Japan measured 9.0 on this scale.



SHOCK WAVES

During an earthquake, radiating shock waves shake the ground like ripples on a pond. Sometimes they liquefy it, just as you can liquefy wet sand on a beach if you paddle it with your foot. This makes it quiver like jelly and then give way beneath tall buildings, making them keel over like capsizing ships.

▼ MAJOR DAMAGE

An earthquake measuring 8.5 on the Richter scale caused this building in Sichuan, China, to collapse in 2008.

